A TOLDOT SPECIAL · 12 NOVEMBER 2026 · 2 KISLEV 5787

The Garments of Esav, the Voice of Yaakov

The twins, the birthright, the garments and the fragrance of the field

---

וַיָּרַח אֶת־רֵיחַ בְּגָדָיו וַיְבָרְכֵהוּ

"And he smelled his clothes and he blessed him" (Bereishit 27:27)

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren — Torah scholar, researcher and writer

The Garments of Esav, the Voice of Yaakov

The twins, the birthright, the garments and the fragrance of the field

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

Prepared on Thursday, 12 November 2026 (2 Kislev 5787), Jerusalem.
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

The fifth portion of Toldot ends in a blind man's tent. Yitzchak cannot see. He has already felt the hands. He has already heard the voice. Then he smells the garments, and he blesses. This note stays with that last sense: the garments, the fragrance, and the twins who brought them into the room. A companion essay of 12 November 2026, *The Voice and the Hands*, already takes up the verse about the voice and the hands. I do not repeat it here.

The twins and the birthright

Before the borrowed coat, there was a stew. When the boys grew up, "Esau became a skillful hunter, a man of the outdoors; but Jacob was a mild man who stayed in camp" (Bereishit 25:27). Esav came in from the open, famished. Yaakov said, "First sell me your birthright." Esav swore, ate, drank, rose and went away. "Thus did Esau spurn the birthright" (Bereishit 25:34).

Rivkah had already heard another word, before they were born: "Two nations are in your womb," and "the older shall serve the younger" (Bereishit 25:23). The sale of the birthright and the blessing in the tent are two scenes in one story. The question in the tent is not only who gets the words. It is what kind of person those words can rest on.

The hinge

Yitzchak feels him and says, "The voice is the voice of Jacob, yet the hands are the hands of Esau" (Bereishit 27:22).

וַיִּגַּשׁ יַעֲקֹב אֶל־יִצְחָק אָבִיו וַיְמֻשֵּׁהוּ וַיֹּאמֶר הַקֹּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב וְהַיָּדַיִם יְדֵי עֵשָׂו׃

That line is the hinge, not the sermon. I already wrote about it in *The Voice and the Hands*. Chazal read it as a promise. In Bereishit Rabbah 65:20, Avnimos the weaver tells the nations: go circulate among their synagogues and study halls; if you find children there crying out in Torah, you will not be able to confront them, for "when the voice of Jacob is found in the synagogues, the hands are not the hands of Esau." I leave the voice as the test, and turn to what Yitzchak smelled.

The garments

Then comes the kiss, and the verse that closes the fifth portion:

וַיִּגַּשׁ וַיִּשַּׁק־לוֹ וַיָּרַח אֶת־רֵיחַ בְּגָדָיו וַיְבָרְכֵהוּ

"Ah, the smell of my son is like the smell of the fields" that G-d has blessed (Bereishit 27:27).

The Gemara in Sanhedrin 37a, in the name of Rabbi Zeira, reads בגדיו, begadav, "his garments," as bogedav, "his traitors." "Do not read “his garments [begadav]”; rather, read: His traitors [bogedav]." Even those who would one day stray still carry a scent worth blessing. The same reading sits in Bereishit Rabbah 65:22, with the stories of Yosef Meshita and Yakum of Tzerorot: people who fell, and whose scent, in the midrash's reading, could still turn back.

That is a hard lesson for anyone who leads a team, a family or a community. A role, a title or a borrowed coat is not the person. Judge first by the voice: what a person learns, says and builds.

The fragrance

Rashi on Bereishis 27:27 asks the plain question. Washed goat-skins should smell foul. Why does Yitzchak bless what he smells? Because "the perfume of the Garden of Eden entered the room with him." Rashi points to Bereishit Rabbah 65:22, where Rabbi Yochanan says that when our patriarch Yaakov entered to his father, "the Garden of Eden entered with him." When Esav entered later, the midrash says Gehenna entered with him.

A coat from Esav's closet carried Eden into a blind man's tent. Pittsburgh taught me that work clothes do not make the man. Jerusalem taught me that G-d can bless through them anyway.

Toward Vayetze

The portion does not end in the tent for long. After the blessing comes the anger, and then the road. "Jacob left Beer-sheba, and set out for Haran" (Bereishit 28:10). Beersheba is the place of the oath, the well named for a promise (Bereishit 26:33). Yaakov leaves that well behind and walks toward Vayetze. After Shabbat, Toldot opens into that departure. The voice has to be strong enough to travel.

Keep the voice strong, and the garments follow.

Sources

English verses are from *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, opened 12 November 2026, with divine names written G-d and L-rd. Hebrew is from the Sefaria Miqra text. Midrash and commentary as linked.

- Bereishit 25:23, 25:27, 25:34; 26:33; 27:22, 27:27; 28:10: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.27.27

- Bereishit Rabbah 65:20 (the voice in the synagogues and study halls): https://www.sefaria.org/Bereshit_Rabbah.65.20
- Bereishit Rabbah 65:22 (the fragrance of Gan Eden, and the bogedav reading): https://www.sefaria.org/Bereshit_Rabbah.65.22
- Rashi on Bereishis 27:27 (Gan Eden; cites Bereishit Rabbah 65:22): https://www.sefaria.org/Rashi_on_Genesis.27.27
- Sanhedrin 37a (Rabbi Zeira, begadav / bogedav): https://www.sefaria.org/Sanhedrin.37a
- Companion, 12 November 2026: *The Voice and the Hands*

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren